

Brass plaque from the royal palace of Benin (image)

Edo peoples, c.1540–70 · Enlarged image · Original: The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York (1990.332)

Cast by Benin's royal guild of brass casters and fixed to the palace's pillars, plaques like this recorded kings, warriors and court ceremonies. They were the palace's archive, not decoration.

Image: The Met, Plaque with Warrior and Attendants, 1990.332, Gift of Mr. and Mrs. Klaus G. Perls, 1990. Open Access (CC0).